RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

He Knows Our Deeds: Principle 10 & Divine Providence

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 15

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: Principle 10 (Hashem knows and attends to human deeds), with **Moreh Nevuchim III:17, 18 and 20**

Shiur: Part 15 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 27 January 2026

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Where We Are

"**We're coming close to the end.**" Principles **1–5**: Hashem Himself. **6–9**: Hashem and humanity: **prophecy**, **Moshe's uniqueness**, **the Torah**, and last week **the Torah never changing** (and whether Nevi'im change in Messianic times).

Where does Principle 10 belong?

	Principles	Theme
Category 3	**11, 12, 13**	**Reward and punishment** (11), **Mashiach** (12), ***Techiyat HaMetim*** (13)
Principle 10	**God's knowledge**	**Could go either way:** a continuation of **6–9** (the divine–human relationship), or **a prelude to 11**, since **Hashem must know our actions for reward and punishment to exist**

Part 1: The Text

היסוד העשירי: כי הוא יתברך יודע מעשיהם של בני אדם ואינו מעלים עינו מהם, לא כדעת מי שאמר ״עזב ה׳ את הארץ״. אלא כמו שנאמר: ״גדל העצה ורב העליליה אשר עיניך פקחות על כל דרכי בני אדם״, ונאמר: ״וירא ה׳ כי רבה רעת האדם בארץ״, ונאמר: ״זעקת סדם ועמרה כי רבה״. וזה מורה על היסוד העשירי הזה.

- **Hashem knows the deeds of human beings and does not turn His eyes from them.**
- **Not like those who say *"Hashem has forsaken the earth"***: created it and **left it to run alone**.

Two parts

10A	**יודע מעשיהם**	**He knows** our actions
10B	**ואינו מעלים עינו מהם**	**He doesn't ignore them**: He doesn't merely know while **paying no attention**; He **acts correspondingly**

Part 2: Actions Only, or Thoughts Too?

"**One academic picked up** that the Rambam says only **יודע מעשיהם**: **deeds**."

	Formulation	Thoughts?
Rambam	**יודע מעשיהם של בני אדם**	**Not stated**
Ani Ma'amin	**שהבורא יתברך שמו יודע כל מעשה בני אדם וכל מחשבותם, שנאמר: היצר יחד לבם, המבין אל כל מעשיהם**	**Adds "and all their thoughts"**
Yigdal	**צופה ויודע סתרינו, מביט לסוף דבר בקדמתו**	**"Our hidden depths"**: seemingly **thoughts too**

"A hundred percent the Rambam meant actions *and* thoughts."

Rav Shilat: when the Rambam writes **וגו׳**, he often means **see the end of the verse**. And **וירא ה׳ כי רבה רעת האדם בארץ** continues: **וכל יצר מחשבת לבו רק רע כל היום**: **all the thoughts of his heart**. "**I think it's not correct to say he limits it to actions.** That's how the Ani Ma'amin understood him too."

Question: How can thoughts count, if I never acted?

"If Hashem doesn't ignore my thoughts, but I never turned them into actions, how is that fair? What about free will?" "**A fair question, and very relevant.**"

#	Point
1. The passing thought	A thought that **pops into your head** carries **no responsibility, good or bad**: "**that's just the brain working of its own accord.**" **The Ba'al HaTanya** stresses: **don't feel bad** about it. **The question is what you do next**: **dwell on and develop it**, or **move on**?
2. Developed bad thoughts	**Mostly not punishable by the strict letter.** Fantasising about **murder**: "**Is it healthy? No. Will he be punished? Likely not.**"
3. The exceptions	Developed thoughts of **avodah zarah** and of **zenut** (promiscuity), **and only if dwelt on**
4. Good thoughts	**Rewarded even if you couldn't carry them out**

Part 3: Three Verses, Three Levels

Why these three verses? Hashem attends to **the individual**, **the city/nation** and **humanity as a whole**.

Hilchot Teshuvah 3:1–2 (which we learned a couple of years ago):

> **כל אחד ואחד מבני האדם יש לו זכיות ועונות. מי שזכיותיו יתירות על עונותיו צדיק, ומי שעונותיו יתירות על זכיותיו רשע, מחצה למחצה בינוני. וכן המדינה: אם היו זכיות כל יושביה מרובות על עונותיהן הרי זו צדקת, ואם היו עונותיהם מרובין הרי זו רשעה. וכן כל העולם כולו.**

Level	Rambam's verse	Hilchot Teshuvah
The individual	**אשר עיניך פקחות על כל דרכי בני אדם** (Yirmiyahu 32:19): **every single person's ways**	**צדיק / רשע / בינוני**
The city	**זעקת סדם ועמרה כי רבה**	**מדינה צדקת / רשעה**
Humanity	**וירא ה׳ כי רבה רעת האדם בארץ** (before the Flood)	**וכן כל העולם כולו**

Part 4: *Hashgachah*: Why It Matters

"**Hashem definitely didn't create the world and leave it**: He's **involved in our day-to-day lives**. That's ***hashgachah***: **משגיח מן החלנות**, **peering in**, **attentive** to what we do."

"**Psychologically, one of our deepest needs is to be noticed.** Small children need lots of attention, and **parents give it**. **We still need it as adults**; it's just covered up. **The more we value someone, the more we yearn for *their attention. So the most important Being in the universe paying attention to our actions should be a source of great chizuk***."

"**Then it suddenly matters whether I wait three hours or six between meat and milk.** Many people say *who cares, what's the difference?* **When we know Hashem is paying attention**, **every action, choice and decision is important.**"

Part 5: Five Views of Providence (Moreh III:17)

"**Ancient views, heard for a long time.**"

#	View	Providence over…	Everything else	Problem
1	**Epicurus** (hence ***apikoros***)	**Nothing**: even the planets and constellations **by chance**; no organiser	All ***mikreh***	"**Even Aristotle** called this unacceptable." **Some Jews held it**: **כחשו בה׳ ויאמרו לא הוא**
2	**Aristotle**	**The heavenly bodies**: Hashem ensures they **run by the laws of nature** (***hashgachah klalit***). "**Even Aristotle accepts an order to the universe**"	**Random**: **a leaf falling = a ship of a thousand people sinking**; **an ox's dung killing ants = a building collapsing on its occupants**; **a spider and a fly = a lion and a righteous man**. "**It's nature.**"	Ignores the individual human
3	**The Ash'ariyya** (Islamic school)	**Everything**: the wind blows **in exactly the proportion Hashem wants**; **every leaf falls by ancient decree, at this time, at this angle**	—	**Fatalism**: **no free will**. "**How can you command mitzvot** if we can't choose? **Our actions become pointless.**" Both philosophically and theologically "very difficult"
4	(A related Islamic school)	**Everything**, like view 3	—	Same, **but humans have free will**
5	**"The view of our Torah" (the Rambam's)**	**Everything relating to humans**	**Random**, as Aristotle held	

The Rambam's view in his words

יסוד תורת משה רבנו… שהאדם בעל יכולת גמורה: **man has complete free will**, and all creatures move **by their own will**, as Hashem wished. "**No doubt** about it".

Side point: reward for animals "**was never heard in our nation**"; **one of the later Geonim**, having heard it from **the Mu'tazila**, thought it correct. "**He means Rav Saadia Gaon**: in ***Emunot veDe'ot*** he held animals receive some reward."

אני מאמין שההשגחה האלהית בעולם השפל הזה, כלומר מתחת לגלגל הירח, היא רק בפרטי מין האדם בלבד… ואילו שאר בעלי החיים, כל שכן הצמחים וזולתם, דעתי בהם כדעת אריסטו.

Below the sphere of the moon, providence is over individual humans alone. Animals, and certainly plants, **as Aristotle said**.

אינני מאמין כלל שהעלה נפל בהשגחה עליו, ולא שהעכביש טרף את הזבוב בגזירה ורצון אלהי פרטי כעת… כל אלו לדעתי במקרה גמור.

A leaf doesn't fall by providence. A spider doesn't catch a fly in its web by a particular divine decree. **Someone spits in the street and kills a creature: not *hashgachah***, "**it was in the wrong place**." **Pure**

chance.

His proofs

Tehillim: ה׳ מה אדם ותדעהו, בן אנוש ותחשבהו; מה אנוש כי תזכרנו, ובן אדם כי תפקדנו: **why do You attend to *man*?** "**Many verses** show Hashem cares about **humans** specifically. **None** about particular parts of nature."

Chavakuk 1:14: ותעשה אדם כדגי הים, כרמש לא משל בו. The prophet, lamenting the destruction: **You've made us like the fish of the sea**. **The Rambam:** *as if we humans were abandoned like the fish and the creatures of the earth*. "**The complaint implies that normally animals have no *hashgachah*. You're treating us like them.**"

Part 6: *Klalit* and *Pratit*

The difficulty: many verses say **Hashem cares for animals**:

- **פותח את ידך ומשביע לכל חי רצון**;

- **נותן לבהמה לחמה, לבני ערב אשר יקראו** (said every morning);

- **הכפירים שאגים לטרף ולבקש מאל אכלם**;

- **The Gemara: יושב הקב״ה וזן מקרני ראמים עד ביצי כנים**: **from the huge *re'em* to lice eggs**.

The Rambam: no contradiction. These are providence over the *species*, not the individual. Animals: *hashgachah klalit*. Humans: *hashgachah pratit*.

The taxi rank

"**I own a taxi rank: 100 black cabs**, all bought the same year, **same condition, same mileage**. I need to **downsize to 80**. **Do I agonise over *which 20? This one I took there, that one I took there? No: whichever 20 first. I care about my taxis as a whole, not the individual cab.* That's*** klalit***.*** Pratit ***is* an affinity to each individual cab**."

"**Lions:** say the world needs **a million lions** and there are a few too many. **Which ones die? Hashem doesn't get involved.** He **sustains the species**: **gives them what they need to exist**."

Why only humans?

The Rambam: "**Like asking why Hashem created the earth**, or **why He gave intellect to humans and not animals**. **I can't answer.** That's what Hashem did, and **detailed, individual providence is for humans**."

"Everything happens for a reason"?

"**This view is quite widespread in Jewish circles**, and **to be fair, it's not without source**. **Apparently the Ba'al Shem Tov held it** ("**I haven't seen it inside**"), and **some Chassidic masters**: **a leaf falls at its moment for a reason**, **like the Islamic school**. **The Rambam clearly didn't believe that. The Ramchal, *lifshuto*, didn't either. That's the view we take.**"

The exception: what belongs to a human

"**If you're a farmer, there's *hashgachah* on your individual sheep**: if one dies, **it affects you**. **Own a cat, and there's *hashgachah* on the cat.**"

"**Lucky are the cats and dogs belonging to humans**: depends on the owner! **Lucky are those belonging to *good* humans. Why *this* cat ended up in a human home and not that one? That's randomness.**"

Question: *If a species goes extinct, is that providence on the species or on each one?*

"**On the species.** For whatever reason, it's **no longer needed**. He doesn't sustain the species, so **the individuals fall away one by one**: **the attention is to the species, *klalit***."

Part 7: Not All Humans Equally (Moreh III:18)

Why do humans have providence? Intellect. So, logically: **the more developed a person, the greater the providence.**

ההשגחה האלהית אינה על כל פרטי מין האדם בשוה, אלא יש שוני בהשגחה עליהם כשוני שלמותם האנושית.

Providence is not equal over all humans; it varies **as their human perfection varies**, in **character and intellect**.

Hence **great *hashgachah* over the righteous**: *I will be with you, I will shield you*; **רגלי חסידיו ישמר**: **He guards the feet of the devout**.

"**Even within the human race, not everyone has *hashgachah. Someone who completely neglects God may be left to randomness. Amalek* said*** mikreh***, everything is chance,* *and they'll be left to chance. You don't want to be left to the whims of nature: come under Hashem's *hashgachah*.**"

Part 8: What Does "God Knows" Mean? (Moreh III:20)

The philosophers' objections

Objection	Argument
New knowledge	**Hashem is perfect** and lacks nothing, so **He can't acquire anything new**. Knowing a human act **when it happens** is new knowledge; **knowing the transient** means **His knowledge changes**, an imperfection. **He can only know the constant and unchanging.**
Plurality	**Humans are many**: knowing them involves **plurality**, but **Hashem's unity** demands **oneness**

The Rambam's response:

הסבה לכל הספקות שבאו... שהם הניחו יחס בין ידיעתנו לידיעתו יתעלה: the source of every doubt is that they assumed a likeness between our knowledge and His.

"**From the human perspective you're a hundred percent right**: if God thinks as humans do, **you have major philosophical problems**. **But His knowledge is part of His essence. Not more clever, but *qualitatively* different. You can't compare it, so you can't ask these questions.**"

In ch. 20: **Hashem can't have new knowledge** (an imperfection), nor **many different thoughts**. Yet **in one knowledge He knows many things**, and **everything that will happen**.

The same key unlocks free will and foreknowledge

If Hashem knows the past, present and future, He knows what I'll choose. So do I have free will?

Thinker	Answer
Rav Saadia Gaon (*Emunot veDe'ot*; "also the Islamic view")	**Foreknowledge isn't determinative.** "**I'll choose what to do tonight after this shiur**, a **full 50–50 choice**, and **Hashem knows what I'll freely choose**"
Rabbeinu Bachya	**Beyond human understanding**: rely on **faith** that they're reconciled
Ralbag (R. Levi ben Gershon) and **Avraham ibn Daud**	**Full free will**; **Hashem willingly curtailed His knowledge** of future human acts, **not an imperfection, because He chose it** ("what that means is a different question")
Chasdai Crescas	**Determinist, not fatalist:** choices follow from **genes, upbringing, parents, school, community**. "**Put all of it in a database and you could predict** what a person will do." **Only Hashem knows the whole mixture.** "**Severely limiting** free choice; **a difficult view**"
The Rambam	"**The best answer, in my view.**" **We live under time**: past, present, future, so the question is unanswerable **for us**. **God's knowledge isn't ours.**

Summary

1. **Principle 10:** Hashem **(A) knows** and **(B) attends to** human deeds and **acts correspondingly**: **not "Hashem has forsaken the earth."**
2. **Thoughts too:** the Rambam's **וכל יצר מחשבת לבו וגו׳** points to **וכל יצר מחשבת לבו**. **Passing thoughts carry no blame**; only **developed** thoughts of **avodah zarah and zenut** are punished; **good intentions are rewarded**.
3. **Three verses, three levels: individual**, **city**, **humanity** (Hilchot Teshuvah 3).
4. ***Hashgachah*** answers **our deep need to be noticed**, and makes **every choice matter**.
5. **Five views: Epicurus** (none), **Aristotle** (heavens only), **Ash'ariyya** (everything, fatalism), **a free-will variant**, and **the Torah's: providence over humans, chance for the rest**.
6. **Animals: *klalit*** (the species; **the taxi rank**). **Humans: *pratit***, plus **what humans own**. "**Everything happens for a reason**" for leaves is **not the Rambam's or the Ramchal's view**.
7. **Providence grows with perfection**: **the righteous are guarded**; the neglectful, **like Amalek**, are left to *mikreh*.
8. **God's knowledge is qualitatively different** (Moreh III:20). That answers both **the philosophers** and **free will vs foreknowledge**.

Coming Up

Next week: Principle 11, reward and punishment. "**About three more shiurim** on the principles, **11, 12 and 13**," then **Moreh Nevuchim on Tuesday nights**. **Next Monday:** the new *sefer* of **Rabbeinu Avraham ben HaRambam**.

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